

Before August 20

Session 1 homework — "Claude as your new employee" Searcy Chamber of Commerce · Next session: Thursday, August 20, 2026, 11:00 AM – 1:00 PM

This page's goal: by August 20 you'll be able to use what you learned on real work without thinking twice — three quick reps make it stick.

Three things. The whole list takes under an hour, spread across two weeks. The single biggest predictor of whether today sticks is whether you open Claude again **this week**.

1. Use it for ten minutes, on three real things

Not practice things. Real ones — things that were already on your list.

Ten minutes each is plenty. Set a timer if that helps. Go to **claude.ai**, or use the desktop app once you've installed it (that's step 2 below).

Remember the three habits:

Give it context. Iterate out loud. Show it an example.

Pick any three of these — or three of your own:

- Write the email you've been avoiding.
- Draft next week's social post, then push it three times until it sounds like you.
- Upload a contract, lease, or policy and ask: *what in here could cost me money, lock me in, or surprise me later?*
- Export a report from your point-of-sale or accounting software as a CSV, upload it, and ask what you should know.
- Turn a page of messy notes into a clean proposal or estimate.
- Write a job posting for the position you keep meaning to fill.
- Draft the polite version of a message you're annoyed about.
- Reply to a bad review without sounding defensive.
- Make a checklist for a task you always explain to new employees out loud.
- Ask it to explain something you've been nodding along about for a year.

Do it inside your "My Business Brain" project if you can — that's the one you built in E7 on your exercise packet. Go to **claude.ai/projects**, open **My Business Brain**, and start the chat from in there. Every time you notice it doesn't know something about you, add a line to the "Set project instructions" box. Two weeks of small edits and it'll know your business better than most people you've hired.

Write down what you did — bring this page back on the 20th:

Task 1: _____

Task 2: _____

Task 3: _____

2. Install the Claude desktop app

You'll want it on your laptop for August 20 — the desktop app is where we'll run Cowork together on the 20th, and it's the most complete way to use it. It works the same whether you're on Windows or on a Mac. It's the same Claude, just living on your computer instead of in a browser tab.

Steps

1. Open a browser and go to **claude.ai/download** (**claude.com/download** works too — same place).
2. Download the installer for your computer and run it.
 - **Windows:** you need Windows 10 or newer.
 - **Mac:** you need macOS 11 (Big Sur) or newer. One download works for both Intel and Apple Silicon Macs.
3. Open the app and sign in with the same account you used today.

The basic chat app works on every plan, and installing it costs nothing.

Done when: Claude opens from your Start menu or your dock, and you can send it a message without opening a browser.

Optional but handy: the phone app is in the Apple App Store and Google Play — search for **Claude by Anthropic**.

☐ Installed and signed in.

3. Bring a mess

For August 20, bring **one messy folder on your laptop, or a stack of PDFs**.

Real mess. Receipts. Invoices. Photos of paperwork. Six versions of the same document named `final_v3_FINAL`. Meeting notes you never typed up. A folder you've been avoiding since spring.

Do not clean it up. The mess is the point.

Here's what we'll do with it. Session 2 is about **Claude Cowork**: instead of you copying things back and forth one message at a time, Cowork lets Claude read, create, and edit files directly in folders you connect on your own computer, finishing a multi-step job end to end from a single description.

So on the 20th, you'll describe an outcome — *"turn these forty receipts into an expense report," "rename this mess so I can find anything," "turn these notes into a proposal"* — instead of describing every step.

Two things worth knowing before you get nervous:

- **You pick the folder.** Claude can only reach files inside folders you explicitly connect and give permission to. Not your whole computer.

- **It asks before it permanently deletes anything.** It shows you a permission box and waits for you to click yes.

☐ Folder or stack picked. Left it messy.

Stuck on any of this?

Bring it on the 20th. Ten minutes before we start is a fine time to say "I couldn't get the app installed" or "mine never made a chart." Somebody else in the room had the same problem, guaranteed.

See you August 20.